BAGHEL BLOWS THE BUGLE

The Chhattisgarh chief minister works towards a second term by sinking differences and using a mix of farm sector initiatives, soft Hindutva, cow and caste politics to get the voters on his side

By Rahul Noronha

It's poll season in Chhattisgarh and Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel is out to win friends and influence people. So when the Congress central leadership elevated his bête noire, health minister T.S. Singh Deo, as the deputy chief minister, Baghel welcomed the move.

The Congress high command had on June 28 convened a meeting in New Delhi to which 16 top leaders from Chhattisgarh, including Baghel, Singh Deo and Pradesh Congress Committee president Mohan Markam, were invited. The stated purpose of the meeting was to strategise for the assembly election in November as also to thrash out any lingering issues among those attending the meeting. The ongoing war between Baghel and Singh Deo and Markam was one such issue. Singh Deo aired his grievances, mainly about being weakened in north Chhattisgarh where he had worked with then state party chief Baghel for a victory in 2018. Singh Deo had complained in the past too, but the party had not taken note. This time, the top Congress leadership not only gave him an ear but also rewarded him. Party president Mallikarjun Kharge announced Singh Deo's elevation as deputy CM—apparently in a bid to resolve differences between him and Baghel. The idea was to prevent the BJP from profiting from the rift. However, a decision on Markam, whose organisational reshuffle ruffled many feathers, is still awaited.

Baghel as state Congress chief in 2018 had led the party to its most comprehensive electoral victory in Chhattisgarh, winning 68 of the 90 seats. In four months, he faces another referendum on his work. While the BJP claims that corruption is at an all-time high, investors are shunning Chhattisgarh and the state has regressed since 2018, Baghel's plan for victory focuses on the farm sector, with a bit of soft Hindutva, cow politics and some deft caste and community manoeuvring thrown in. Will his efforts pay off?

First up are the farm sector initiatives that Team Bhupesh thinks is their biggest vote catcher. The Chhattisgarh government wrote off farm loans as part of the Congress's 2018 electoral promise. Payment of a bonus on paddy procurement is another clincher. The state government pays farmers an effective price of Rs 2,500 per quintal of paddy, the highest for any state in the country. This includes the minimum support price announced by the Union government (Rs 2,040 and Rs 2,060 in 2022); the remainder is a bonus paid by the state in four instalments. The maximum quantity of paddy a farmer can sell to the government has been increased to 20 quintals per acre from 15 earlier. Those who do not grow paddy get a flat Rs 10,000 per acre. The Congress thinks the Rajiv Gandhi Kisan Nyay Yojana under which this disbursement is being made is the game changer. But with the election approaching, there is talk that the procurement amount will be hiked to Rs 2,800. Enthused by the positive feedback, the government also plans to procure other crops, including pulses and coarse grains.

There is a fundamental difference between how the BJP looks at the farmers and how the Congress government in Chhattisgarh considers it as a voting group. The BJP-led Union government under the PM Kisan Samman Nidhi pays money directly to farmers but the scheme covers only small and marginal cultivators. In BJP-ruled states like Madhya Pradesh, the PM Kisan Samman Nidhi amount is augmented by the CM Kisan Samman Nidhi, but is payable only to small and marginal farmers. The BJP's idea is to cater to bigger numbers—there